

A photograph of a person in an orange protective suit and helmet standing on a massive, translucent, yellowish-white selenite crystal. The crystal is part of a larger formation in a cave, with other similar crystals visible in the background. The person is positioned in the center-left of the frame, providing a sense of scale to the enormous size of the crystals.

# Crystal cave

**In extremely hot and humid conditions, these scientists are investigating the largest crystals ever found, in the Giant Crystal Cave, Naica, Mexico.**

The crystals are made of selenite, a form of the mineral gypsum (calcium sulfate), which is the main ingredient of plaster and blackboard chalk. The crystals form very slowly from calcium, sulfur, and oxygen dissolved in hot water. This water was heated by magma in a geological fault beneath the cave. The largest crystals weigh 55 tons and are 39 ft (12m) long.